because I do have some regrets about that happening.

Batting at that level at such a young age became a struggle for survival rather than just trying to play a normal game. And I had to deal with the public's high expectations. Being thrown in at the deep end definitely set my progress back a few years.

But all that was on the field. Off the field, it was another story. As a 16-year-old, I had access to a world inhabited by South Africa's top sportsmen. And that world, let me tell you, was one helluva lot of fun …

It started with my little initiation ceremony into the A-team, of which teammate Kenny Jackson was the orchestrator. I would have to go through the infamous 'dip' initiation. My initiation took place before they remodelled Newlands, so the 'ceremony' took place in the old Pavilion, where the admin offices used to be.

'Get your boy out!' commanded Kenny, trying hard to sound authoritative, but not doing a very good job of it. So I had to drop my rods, get out my 'boy' and lay it out on a desk. Kenny had a piece of string – it could've been a bootlace – in his hand and he proceeded to lash my boy six times. Once or twice, it actually hurt. After the lashing – and this is where the little ritual gets its name from – the team pours you a glass of beer and you have to dip your boy in the beer. And then – you guessed it – you have to down the beer. It was a little bit cold putting the boy in the beer, but, you know, it was all smiles afterwards. It was a lovely little initiation.

The first few years I played for Province were wonderful, as my teammates were a bloody mischievous bunch of lads – both the A- and the B-team guys.

Of the B-team players, I would hang out with Alan Dawson and Lance Bleekers – two *very* naughty okes. Not that the rest of them were angels – not at all! The likes of Dean Payne, Tim Mitchell and Ian Solomon – and even our coach, Hylton Ackerman – certainly enjoyed a party or three.

I remember one evening in Pietermaritzburg when we went out for a team supper and had a few drinks. I was rooming with Vinnie Barnes at the time. Vinnie is currently the Proteas bowling coach, but he was then playing for Province. He and I went on to become close friends.

So, anyway, after supper, some of us – me, Bleekie, Dawsie, Ian Solomon and Dean Payne – were in the lift on our way to our rooms when the decision was taken to hit the town. Out we went. The drinks flowed freely, as they tended to when we were socialising, and we stumbled back to